American Political Thought

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Course Description

This course examines political ideas that have emerged in the United States from the Founding. It will consider those ideas revealed in the debates concerning the American Founding, the American Civil War, Progressivism, and the Civil Rights Movement. It will also consider how the American government relates to the larger tradition of Western political thought.

Learning Objectives

- Understand the principles, purposes, institutions, and mores that constitute American government.
- Understand the debate over the U.S. Constitution's creation and ratification.
- Understand the debate over slavery, secession, and popular sovereignty.
- Understand the contemporary debates in American political thought.
- Improve our ability to read closely.
- Sharpen our ability to make good arguments.

Course Requirements

Grading	**Weight**
Participation	10%
Short Paper and Presentation	20%
Midterm Exam	35%
Final Exam	35%

Attendance: I will expect you to attend all scheduled classes. If emergencies prevent you from attending, please let me know as soon as possible.

Participation (10%): Please read, take notes, and think about all assigned readings before class. I encourage participation in the form of questions and comments.

Short Paper and Presentation (20%): Each week one seminar participant will be required to give a presentation on the material to be discussed during that meeting and submit a 7-10 page paper by the next class.

Midterm Exam (35%) and **Final Exam** (35%): You will be required to write your answers in response to the prompts I provide on the exam dates.

Course Schedule

Week 1: Introduction

- No required reading

Week 2: Benjamin Frankilin

- Benjamin Franklin, *The Autobiography* In *Franklin: The Autobiography and Other Writings on Politics, Economics, and Virtue.* ed. Alan C. Houston (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004)

Week 3: Natural Rights Theory

- Alexander Hamilton, "The Farmer Refuted" (1775)
- "Declaration of Independence" (1776)
- (Optional) Thomas Paine, *Common Sense* In *Paine: Collected Writings* (New York: Library of America, 1995)

Week 4: The Principles of the American Government

- The United States Constitution Articles I–VII.
- Alexander Hamilton, James Madison, and John Jay, *The Federalist* (Middletown, Conn.: Wesleyan University Press, 1961) Nos. 1, 2, 9, 10, 14, 37, 39, 51, 85.

Week 5: The Anti-Federalists

- "The Federal Farmer 1" (1787)
- "Brutus 1" (1787)
- Patrick Henry, "Speech Before Virginia Ratifying Convention" (1788)
- The United States Constitution Amendments I–X.
- (Optional) Herbert Storing, *What the Anti-Federalists Were For* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1981)

Week 6: Tocqueville's View of American Democracy

- Alexis de Tocqueville. *Democracy in America* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000), Volume I

Week 7: Pro-Slavery Ideology

- John C. Calhoun, "Speech on the Reception of Abolition Petitions" (1837); "On the Oregon Bill" (1848)

- George Fitzhugh, *Cannibals All! or, Slaves Without Masters* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2009), Chapter 1.
- Alexander H. Stephens, "Cornerstone Speech" (1961)

Week 8: Midterm Exam

Week 9: Abolitionists

- William Lloyd Garrison, "Fourth of July Address" (1829); "Opening Statement of the First Issue of the Liberator" (1831).
- Frederick Douglass, "The Right to Criticize American Institutions" (1847); "The Constitution and Slavery" (1849); "What to the Slave is the Fourth of July?" (1852)
- (Optional) Frederick Douglass. *Autobiographies*. ed., Henry Louis Gates. (New York: Literary Classics of the United States, 1994)

Week 10: Abraham Lincoln I

- Abraham Lincoln, "Address to the Young Men's Lyceum of Springfield" (1838); "Speech on the Kansas-Nebraska Act at Peoria, Illinois" (1854); "Speech on the Dred Scott Decision" (1857); "House Divided Speech" (1858); "First Lincoln-Douglas Debate, Ottawa" (1858); "Seventh Lincoln-Douglas Debate, Alton" (1858); "Speech at Columbus, Ohio" (1859)
- (Optional) Harry V. Jaffa, *Crisis of the House Divided : An Interpretation of the Issues in the Lincoln-Douglas Debates* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2009)

Week 11: Abraham Lincoln II

- Abraham Lincoln, "Farewell Address at Springfield, Illinois" (1861); "Speech at Independence Hall, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania" (1861); "First Inaugural Address" (1861); "Proclamation Revoking General Hunter's Emancipation Order" (1862); "Address to Border-State Representatives for Compensated Emancipation" (1862); "Address on Colonization" (1862); "Final Emancipation Proclamation" (1863); "Gettysburg Address" (1863); "Second Inaugural Address" (1865); "Speech on Reconstruction" (1865)

Week 12: Progressivism

- Woodrow Wilson, *Constitutional Government in the United States* (New York: The Columbia University Press, 1908), Chapter 3; "What is Progress?" (1913)
- (Optional) Theodore Roosevelt, "The New Nationalism" (1910)
- (Optional) Franklin D. Roosevelt, "Annual Message to Congress" (1944)

- (Optional) Lyndon B. Johnson, "Remarks at the University of Michigan" (1964)

Week 13: Racial Equality

- Booker T. Washington. "Atlanta Exposition Speech" (1895)
- W. E. B. Du Bois. "The Conservation of Races" (1897); "The Talented Tenth" (1903)
- Martin Luther King, Jr. "Letter from Birmingham Jail" (1963); "I Have a Dream" (1963)
- (Optional) Booker T. Washington, *Up from Slavery* (G&D Media, 2020)
- (Optional) W. E. B. Du Bois, *The Souls of Black Folk* (Amherst: UMass Amherst Libraries, 2018)

Week 14: John Rawls

- John Rawls, *The Theory of Justice* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1999), Chapters 1-3.

Week 15: Conservatism

- Allan Bloom, *The Closing of the American Mind: How Higher Education Has Failed Democracy and Impoverished the Souls of Today's Students* (Riverside: Simon & Schuster, 2008)
- (Optional) Harry V. Jaffa *American Conservatism and the American Founding* (Durham, N.C.: Carolina Academic Press, 1984)
- (Optional) Leo Strauss, *Natural Right and History* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1953)

Week 16: Final Exam